DILEMMA

IS NO STRANGER TO POLITICAL NEPOTISM



ALL ABOARD Union ministers Narendra Tomar (centre) and Kiren Rijiju (right) welcome Amarinder Singh (left) and PLC leaders to the BJP

2 NO. OF BJP CHIEF MINISTERS (AND A DEPUTY CM) WHO COME FROM POLITICAL FAMILIES

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

IT is one of the deepest paradoxes of Indian democracy, the way it is—and widely perceived to be—subject to capture by an entrenched elite, whose best skill, like that of any robust species, is self-propagation. In common parlance, we call it dynastic politics. It comes in many shades. There's the old elite—the erstwhile royal houses, who exemplify political dynasty like none else, going back to pre-1947 days. Then there's the political nouveau riche, who behave no differently. So when Prime Minister Narendra Modi said during his Independence Day address from the ramparts of the Red Fort that he was particularly vexed by two major challenges facing the country—*parivarvaad* (nepotism) and corruption—he was tapping into a widely disseminated public anger over the issue.

Modi also said the two were intertwined: *parivarvaad* breeds corruption. The ruling BJP portrays itself as standing aloof from this culture, and thus morally invested with the right to deride other parties on this, but how does the party actually fare in this area? Well, on October 8, less than two months after the PM's speech, the party announced candidates for the November assembly bypolls in Adampur in Haryana, Munugode in Telangana and Gola Gokarnnath in